Buffering & Swarming

Protect capacity for the unexpected, and agree when the team stops starting and gathers to finish.

Manage Flow · Capacity Buffer · Swarm Triggers · Stop Starting, Start Finishing

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TEAM: Basket team

DATE: 9 May

1 Unplanned Work History

HOW MUCH SURPRISE WORK DO WE REALLY GET?

ITERATION	PLANNED CAPACITY	UNPLANNED WORK	% UNPLANNED	NOTES
Sprint 14	7 items	2	22%	payments bug
Sprint 15	8	1	11%	
Sprint 16	7	3	30%	Saturday incident
Sprint 17	8	2	20%	Stock API workaround
Sprint 18	8	2	20%	test data

Average % unplanned over the last 5: about 20%

2 Size the Buffer

Buffer this iteration (%): 20%

In days or items: about 2 items

The buffer is for:

- [x] Support, incidents & bugs
- [x] Urgent requests
- [x] Swarming & helping others
- [ ] Improvement work, if unused

3 Buffer Rules

What counts as unplanned?
anything not in the plan when the sprint starts

Who decides to use it?
whoever is on the support rota

If it runs out, we...
Priya swaps out the lowest item

If it's unused, we...
pull in a tech debt item

4 Swarm Triggers

WHEN WE STOP STARTING AND SWARM

- [x] An item is blocked for more than 4 hours
- [x] An item is older than 9 days (our 85% SLE)
- [x] An item the goal depends on is at risk with 3 days left
- [x] A production incident at severity 2 or higher
- [x] A column is at its WIP limit

Our own trigger: someone says "I'm stuck" at two syncs in a row

5 How We Swarm

AGREE IT BEFORE YOU NEED IT

1 Stop
Don't start anything new. Say "swarm" at the board.
Our note: Tom calls it at the board

2 Gather
Whoever can help joins. Not everyone needs to, just enough.
Our note: 2 or 3 people, not everyone

3 Plan
What's the next step to finish it? Who does which part?
Our note: 5 minutes, at the board

4 Work it
Pair or mob. Test while building. Clear the blocker.
Our note: mob in the Basket room

5 Reflect
Done? Log it below. Why did it need a swarm at all?
Our note: at the next daily sync

6 Swarm Log

LEARN FROM EVERY SWARM

DATE	ITEM	TRIGGER	WHO SWARMED	TIME TO DONE	WHAT WE LEARNED
6 May	Substitute flag bug	blocked 4+ hours	Sam, Jo, Alex	1 day	pair on payments code
29 Apr	Reorder double-adds	older than 9 days	Jo, Ravi	2 days	split it earlier
5 Apr	Checkout outage	severity 2 incident	Sam, Platform	4 hours	we need better alerts

7 Iteration Check

AT THE RETRO

Buffer used last iteration (%): 25%

Number of swarms: 3

Did swarming finish things faster?

- [x] Yes
- [ ] Partly
- [ ] No

Next iteration's buffer (%): 20%, unchanged

"What would we stop starting so we could finish this?"

"How much of our plan is really for surprises?"

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